Sonnets for an Old Century – Cutting 1

By Jose Rivera

WENDY JOHNSON (pg 121)

You stand here and make your statement.

That's it.

You want to fight with existence?

Go for it. You want to scream?

Knock yourself out.

Just remember:

your words go out to the universe, all your

words, to be, I don't know, recycled among

the living -- like rain, like part of --

some ecology of the spirit.

It's the last and only time you have

to give your side of the story, as far as I

know.

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INTRODUCTION

In a waiting room for the afterlife, we find a dreamscape filled with poignant and haunting monologues from recently deceased individuals. "Where do we go when we die?" And if you were to offer commentary regarding the life that you've lived, "What would you say?"

In this selection we hear from a woman and her husband, both with very different views about her life choices. Sonnets for an Old Century by Jose Rivera

ANA ORTIZ (pg 150)

There's somebody ... I don't know who he is ...

I want to take this time to apologize to

him. I don't know your name. I don't know

what you look like.

You were in the Bronx about seven years

ago. Let's see, it was outside the 180th

Street shop on the Two, close to one in the

morning. I don't remember the name of

the street anymore.

But right there, under the elevated tracks,

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at the intersection, on the left as you go east, one night seven years ago ... I saw you. It was very dark there. All I wanted to do was to get home. So I'm walking fast 'cause I hate that street and I almost didn't see you. But I did see you.

Two men were holding you by the arms and they were slamming you headfirst into the front of a parked car. I couldn't see your face. The two guys were laughing. You fell to the ground. I only watched for a second.

I got out of there as fast as I could. I went home. I didn't call the cops. I didn't call for help. I didn't jump in to break it up. I didn't go back later to see if you were okay. I didn't do nothing but run. Protect my ass.

For a second I actually convinced myself

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that you guys were playing some kind of game, maybe you were just kids.

I'm sorry. If you're out here. If you're hearing this. I was the one who walked away that night and left you there and I haven't been able to stop thinking about you in seven years and I thought, here, now, this would be the time to say I was sorry. This would be the time.

Please forgive me, sir. Please forgive me.

TRANSITION

But apologies mean little, and definitely won't change the fate of your soul, unless the apology leads to a change. Listen as the speaker's husband describes the woman he married. Time has definitely made a difference, but in her attempts to redeem herself, did she simply go too far?

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ROBERT MONTANO (pg 145)

My wife ...

... she gave her old clothes to a local church
... she knew the mailman's birthday ...
she gave to UNICEF ...
she sent passionate faxes to elected officials ...
she knew the first
twelve Shakespeare sonnets by heart ...
she said good-bye to tollbooth people ...
"bye-bye tollbooth person!" ...
she returned her library books on time ...
she visited her eternal grandmother
every faithful summer ...
the old woman's one remaining pleasure ...
incontinent, toothless, unhappy ...
connecting her granddaughter,
through endlessly repeated anecdotes,
to the history written in her blood ...

. . . she swore she'd buy herself a gun

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and shoot herself in the head
before she'd put up with an old age like this ...
we planned to get ancient together
and. do. the joint-suicide thing ...

... but there was a guy ...

... a guy who washes car windows
in front of the bank in our neighborhood ...
young guy ...
filthy ...
heroin ...
always had a skateboard ...
she'd drive up to the bank ...
give him a dollar to clean the windshields ...

. . . they'd hang out and talk ...
they did this every Saturday morning ...
he's very good-looking ...
despite the filth ...

... she used to shoot up, so she understood ...

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I thought they were in love ...
they had "a thing" ...
I waited in the car as they laughed ...
she once gave him a twenty,
got in the car, crying ...
she said, "I just heard the saddest story" ...

... his new tattoo ...
I swore it was her name
surrounded by a crown of thorns ....
the woman he couldn't have ...
I wanted to kill this man . . .
he was pathetic ...
smelled like a urinal ...
she got too *close* to him ...
I didn't want his clothes to brush her
clothes ... came home one day ...
there he is *in the kitchen* ...
merrily drinking coffee ...
he's talking to her about movies ...
big fan of Hitchcock ...

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what the **** is going on here? ...
I wanted to unwind ...
I'm stuck with this putrid drug user
in my kitchen
pontificating about *Strangers on a Train!* ...

... we fought about it that night ...
I told her: "I come home ...
I can't even talk to you
because this addict is monopolizing you ...
all I want is equal rights here!" ...
she said,
"I already know what you're going to tell
me" ...
I stare at her ...
"I *bore* you? ...
is that it?" ...
"no," she said quickly ...
I didn't even stay in bed to hear more ...
she said, "these people need me" ...
"I don't need you?" ...

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she said, "not in the same way" ...
"honey, I need you in profound ways" ...
she said, "yes I know" ...
"you're not going to save this man" ...

... I couldn't stop imagining them together ...
... I imagined they rode skateboards
together... panhandling in front of our
house ..
all our friends staring at her ...
and she'd look and sound happier
with him than she ever looked and sounded
with me ...
beneath the layers of traffic soot
and sidewalk dirt
her eyes were full of wisdom and fulfillment
and absolute freedom ...
the freedom only vaguely imagined
by the housebound ...
freedom to say "**** you" ...
to stare at the drivers

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waiting for the light to change ...
she'd challenge them:
"hey you in the Lexus, are you moral?
empathic? ...
you think you are ...
you tell your children you are ...
in your prayers you boast that you are ...
yet here I am ...
LOOK AT ME ...
I'm staring into the deepest tunnels
of your heart
and I'm not seeing **** ...
you want me gone ...
you hope I fall off the edge
of the known world ...
fall painlessly into oblivion
while you drive to your appointments" ...

... she wanted that power ...
and that power was something
she could only get from him ...

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... then he disappeared ...

... after that we would drive together ...
anywhere ...
didn't matter ...
there they were ...
like an army of vampires,
bloodless, in their rags and filth ...
they knew about her ...
they sought her out ...
she radiated goodness and they wanted it ...
they wanted to drink from her kindness
like it was an ancient tribal river ...
to suck her down into their limbs ...
to own her ...

... my wife ...
actually began to disappear in front of my
eyes ... I watched helpless as she gave away
scraps of herself ...
first the excess ...

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then the vital tissues ...
until she disappeared completely from my
sight ... down into the tortured piranha pit
of the homeless ...

... away from me ...
happy ...
alive ...
and finally at home.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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